WHAT AB-620 ACTUALLY TESTS

AB-620 measures whether you can ship, not whether you can describe.

The exam splits the work into five domains, weighted by what shows up first in a working consultant's week: planning, building, knowledge, integration, and operations. It rewards designers who balance choices, not maximalists who max everything.

FORMAT

Mostly scenario-based questions

Pick what you'd actually build, defend it. A few multiple-choice, but the spine is "here's a story — what do you do?"

TIME

120 minutes, paced

First pass: leave the questions you're unsure. Second pass: revisit. Don't burn time you don't have.

THE AUDIENCE THE EXAM ASSUMES

Functional consultants, makers, and admins already shipping agents — who want the credential to land.

AB·620

AI AGENT BUILDER ASSOCIATE

WHAT IT TESTS IN ONE LINE

The judgement of a working consultant, not the memory of a Microsoft Learn page.

WHAT IT DOES NOT TEST

Memorised feature lists, buzzword bingo, or speed — the time is ample.

THE PRACTICAL SHAPE

Read the scenario, weigh two choices, defend the third. Then move on.

Sit it after shipping one real agent for a real team — not before.

FIVE DOMAINS · WEIGHT SUMMARY

A weighted view of the week, not a museum of features.

Plan and configure carries the most weight; operations carries the least. Numbers shift between blueprints; the shape of the work does not.

DOMAIN 01

Plan & configure

30–35%

Use cases, environments, DLP, ALM, connectors, governance planning.

DOMAIN 02

Build agents

25–30%

Topics, triggers, generative orchestration, Power Fx, slot filling.

DOMAIN 03

Knowledge & RAG

15–20%

Sources, grounding, citations, Azure AI Search, governance.

DOMAIN 04

Integrate & extend

10–15%

Connectors, MCP, A2A, agent flows, custom prompts.

DOMAIN 05

Test & manage

10–15%

Pipelines, channels, governance, monitoring, lifecycle.

RELATIVE WEIGHT AT A GLANCE

Five bands, scaled to each domain’s share



READ LEFT TO RIGHT · TOTAL MAPS TO A WORKING CONSULTANT’S WEEK

If only one band were dressed up, it would still be honest; the test rewards breadth.

FIVE MOTIONS TO RECOGNISE

Every scenario is some subset of these. Memorise the verbs.

Read each scenario as a verb. What is the maker **doing** in the situation — not what feature the page mentions.

MOTION 01

Pick the right tool for the job

Restraint over decoration. Sometimes the answer is a topic, sometimes a connector, sometimes a peer agent — the job chooses; maker follows.

MOTION 02

Pick the right boundary

Trust boundary, environment boundary, latency/credit boundary. Choose one and defend it; don't fuzz.

MOTION 03

Pick the right level of automation

Generative orchestration, agent flow, classic routing. Three options, three costs, three blast radii.

MOTION 04

Pick the right cadence

Authoring, validating, packaging, promoting, observing. The loop has a rhythm; the loop owns the answer.

MOTION 05

Pick the right level of governance

Roles, telemetry, retirement. The product doesn't ship alone; the people around it don't either.

Read the scenario, name the motions, write the answers. The exam rewards **scenarios well explained**, not feature lists.

DOMAIN 01

WEIGHT

30–35%

NAME

Plan & configure

The broad domain — it sets up everything else. If you skip this, you build on sand.

KEY ABILITIES

- Identify use cases and patterns
- Plan environments and DLP
- Plan ALM and governance
- Pick connectors and shared bits

WHAT SHOWS UP ON THE PAGE

Choose before designing; defend your choices.

RECOGNISE USE CASES

What does the agent exist to do — in one sentence.

A scenario without a job is a feature demo. The exam gives you a story; the first task is naming the value.

ENVIRONMENTS & DLP

One floor per purpose, walls between.

Dev / test / prod, data policies that match the trust boundary, connection references typed upstream of the agent.

ALM & LIFECYCLE

Solutions, pipelines, readiness

You will author twice if you skip this the first time.

CONNECTORS & SHARED BITS

Pick by reuse, not by ease

Standard where available, premium where licensed, custom when nothing fits.

If the scenario does not mention a plan, defend a plan anyway. **A grounded answer is rarely accidental**; it picks on purpose.

RULE OF THE DOMAIN

Name the value, name the boundary, name the lifecycle. Then write code.

DOMAIN 02 · BUILD AGENTS

Build is the verb the rest of the deck modifies.

Topics, triggers, generative orchestration, Power Fx, slot filling — these are how the agent holds a conversation. The exam asks how you shape the conversation given a scenario.

A TOPIC, SCHEMATICALLY

TRIGGER PHRASES
What the user might say

CONDITIONS
Branch on context

VARIABLES
Carry, fill, hand off

Plus: a system prompt, an action or two, an adaptive card, and a fallback topic.

Topics are an island of behaviour, not a script. Generative orchestration may step over them.

EXAM CUES
“Choose generative orchestration when…” · “When do you add a Power Fx step?” · “Where does slot filling help?”

A RULE FOR THE EXAM

Build the smallest conversation that answers the scenario — then add only what the scenario really needs.

Add a topic when the conversation has a branch. Add a flow when the work has a step. Add a tool when the answer needs a real source.

THREE COMMON FALSE CHOICES

TEMPTING, WRONG

Generative orchestration for everything

It pulls speed — and cost. Deterministic steps still earn their slot.

TEMPTING, WRONG

A topic for every phrase

Topic graphs sprawl. Generative orchestration is the leukocyte — pick fewer, do more.

TEMPTING, WRONG

Power Fx when an answer would do

Reach for code where structure helps, not where an answer suffices.

TEMPTING, RIGHT

Name the smallest shape first; shape the answer around it.

Trigger → condition → variable → answer. Add when needed.

DOMAIN 03 · KNOWLEDGE AND RAG

Grounded answers, not confident ones. Trust boundary, not feature count.

Sources, retrieval, citations, governance. The agent can talk fluently about topics it doesn't know; grounding is the discipline that stops it.

SHAREPOINT

Sites you own

Honours permissions. Default choice.

DATAVERSE

Tables you author

Rows and columns; 15 tables per source.

PUBLIC WEB

Anchored URL lists

Vendor docs, public KBs.

AZURE AI SEARCH

Search index you control

Hybrid + filters; for big bodies.

EXAM CUES

Choices you make on this domain

· Pick the source that matches the trust boundary, not the easiest one.

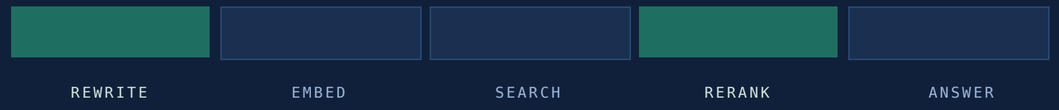
· Tune rewrite and rerank; cite the snippet that backs the claim.

· Schedule refresh — "no incidents" comes from "refresh on a timer".

GROUNDED VS CONFIDENT, A FLOW

Rewrite → embed → search → rerank → answer.

Five moves. Tune the second and fourth; accept the rest.



Bright steps are the ones you tune in production.

DOMAIN 04 · INTEGRATE & EXTEND

Extensions earn the agent its hands — and its risk.

Connectors, MCP, A2A, agent flows, computer-use, custom prompts. The exam asks you to pick the smallest extension that fits the scenario.

A PACKAGE, ANONYMOUS

Custom connector

You wrap the API; the agent calls it.

Verb-named actions, schema-bound.

A CONTRACT, SHARED

MCP tool

Borrow someone's vocabulary.

Name, describe, args — they did it.

A PEER, NAMED

A2A

Hand off to another agent.

Bring back a typed result.

A STRUCTURE, AUTOMATIC

Agent flow

Deterministic work, typed I/O.

Run alone or delegate from a topic.

EXAM CUES

What the rubric looks for

· Pick the smallest extension that closes the gap.

· Computer-use is the last ten percent, not the first.

· Errors are extensions too — design for the refuse.

· Multi-agent when ownership or lifecycle split; never to look impressive.

The agent's blast radius is the union of its extensions.

A STACK TO REMEMBER

Reasoning → orchestration → extension

Reasoning model	DECIDES
Generative orchestration	ROUTES
Extensions	ACTS

Errors, governance, telemetry live one layer up — not on the boxes above.

DOMAIN 05 · TEST AND MANAGE

Trust is built by the people around the agent, not just the maker.

Test pane, analytics, channels, lifecycle, governance, monitoring. The exam asks who owns what — and where the rollback lives.

VALIDATING

Test pane & eval sets

Walk through real questions; build an eval set; assert pass on a gate.

Done once, run forever.

SURFACES

Channels & lifecycles

Teams, web, custom. Dev, test, prod.

Pick the audience first.

OPERATING

Pipelines & lifecycle

Managed solutions, env-stratified deploys.

Replayable, not handmade.

WATCHING

Signals & governance

Resolution, errors, escalations, costs.

Four roles on the wall.

EXAM CUES

One person can hold two roles; no one holds all four.

ROLES

maker · reviewer · owner · admin

WHAT THE PAGE MEASURES

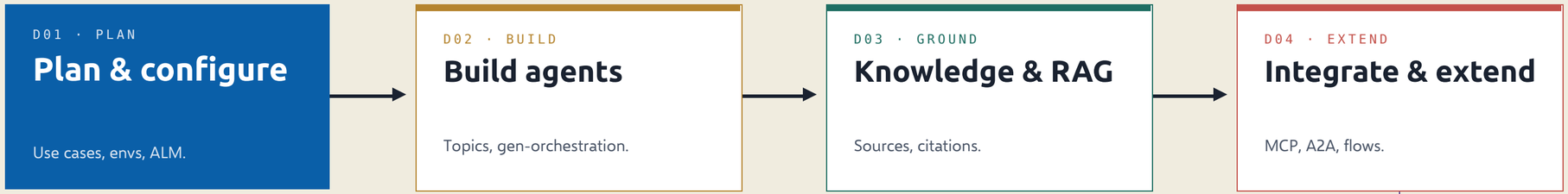
The exam asks: who owns rollback, who watches the dashboard, who retires the agent.

THE TEST FOR OWNERSHIP **Can any of them act alone?**	**Who makes**	**Who signs off**	**Who retires**

FIVE DOMAINS · HOW THEY HANG TOGETHER

No domain is alone. They depend and overlap on purpose.

Read a scenario, draw the dependencies, answer the question in the order those dependencies force.



WATCH · ALWAYS

D05 · ALWAYS RUNNING

Test, deploy, monitor, retire

Test pane, channels, deployment pipelines, governance, monitoring. The loop is overlaid on everything above; nothing ships without it.

FORWARD ARROW

Each step enables the next; skipping leaves gaps.

LOOP ARROW

Watch what you ship and feed it back; the cycle is the product.

A scenario lands in one domain, but answers often travel through **all five**. Trace what changes, name the dependencies, write the answer.

QUESTION SHAPES YOU WILL MEET

Most questions wear one of four hats. Recognise the hat; the answer follows.

The exam reuses a small set of shapes. Train your eye to read the shape first, then read the words.

SHAPE A

“Which would you do?”

A pick from two or three candidates. Defend the choice with one sentence; the rubric credits the choice and its reason both.

SHAPE B

“What will go wrong if…?”

A risk-spotting shape. Pick the most likely failure, name the second, and offer the cheap mitigation. Don’t list everything.

SHAPE C

“Order these…”

A sequence. Show stages; defend the order when the rubric wants reasoning, not answer only.

SHAPE D

“Design the solution”

Build a thing. Include the smallest diagram, name the lifecycle, defend the choice.

Read the shape. Write the answer shaped to fit.

SCENARIO A · PRACTICE

An HR concierge for 8,000 employees. Pick the architecture that survives payroll week.

HR asks for an agent that answers policy & benefits questions, opens tickets for edge cases, and **never** shows a manager's comp data to a peer. What do you build?

THE BRIEF, PARAPHRASED

Answer policy & benefits. Open a ticket for edge cases. Never leak comp data across reporting lines.

CONSTRAINTS YOU MUST INHERIT

- One tenant, three regions, ~8,000 employees
- Pay and band tables must not surface in answers
- Edge cases route to a ticket, not a guess
- Owned by HR; built by IT; reviewed by Privacy

WHAT THE RUBRIC WILL REWARD

Trust boundary named · fallback named · lifecycle named.

OPTION 01 · TEMPTING, WRONG

Single agent, one big SharePoint source, no filters

Reads "pick one source" as "pick everything." Pulls pay tables into answers when the question drifts. Comp leak waiting to happen.

OPTION 02 · DEFENDS WELL

Two sources, scoped: one public KB site · one Dataverse ticket table

Honours site boundaries; cites KB only; opens tickets through an action. Pay tables stay out by construction.

OPTION 03 · TEMPTING, WRONG

A2A to a third-party payroll bot, called on every benefits question

Pays a third party to keep answering your own policy. Latency and roles multiply for no value.

SCENARIO B · PRACTICE

A field-tech agent must resist the temptation to click when it cannot read.

A field-tech opens cases in a legacy desktop app and a vendor portal — both without APIs. The team proposes “turn on computer-use.” Do you?

THE SCENARIO

A field-tech agent must read the next case from a legacy desktop, look up a serial-number record on a vendor portal, and open a ticket on the customer’s behalf — every shift, 200 times a day.

OPTION 01 · WRONG, MOSTLY

Computer-use, today, on both apps

Two UIs, 200 invocations a day, no fall-back. One vendor admin pushes a button; everything breaks for a week.

The exam reads: blast radius > competence.

OPTION 02 · DEFENDS, WITH A CAVEAT

Custom connector for the vendor portal; human handoff for the legacy app

Resolve the smaller target first via API, defer the harder one until a connector exists.

The exam reads: smallest extension that closes the gap.

OPTION 03 · TEMPTING, WRONG

A2A to an AI-only agent that runs the legacy app

A second unsupervised agent, used full-time, with the same brittle environment. Blast radius doubled, not halved.

DECISION · DEFEND IT

Pick option 02. Wrap the portal in a connector, hand off the legacy app to a human queue, time-box the gap with a metric.

The exam rewards picking the smaller extension and naming the second-best alternative — not the most ambitious.

WATCH-FORS

- **Computer-use is the last ten percent, not the first**
- **Suppress a flow on errors; don’t blanket retry**
- **Retire the human queue the day the connector lands**

SCENARIO C · PRACTICE

Triage, then three specialists. One orchestrator, four owners.

A customer service intake has three specialists — refunds, scheduling, technical — that each have their own lifecycle, owners, and DLP. How do you wire this?

ORCHESTRATOR

Triage agent

Owns the user, the room, the rule of "who next." Channel-agnostic; Teams / web / IVR.

Owner: Service lead.

SPECIALIST A

Refund agent

SPECIALIST B

Scheduling agent

SPECIALIST C

Technical agent

Read-only diagnostic, escalation to a human queue. Owns its own knowledge.

WHY THREE, NOT ONE

Each has its own lifecycle & owner.

Refunds retire seasonally; scheduling is shared with field-ops; tech rolls into a release train. Never collide.

THREE RULES YOU MUST KEEP

SCOPE THE SOURCE

Refund agent sees only refund KB

Knowledge trusts itself; one agent per source keeps the trust boundary clean.

SEPARATE THE HANDLER

One ALM pipeline per specialist

Shipping refunds shouldn't require scheduling sign-off; pipelines enforce this.

DESIGN THE RETIREMENT

Multi-agents retire independently

A retiring specialist must hand the user back to the orchestrator, not vanish mid-conversation.

Multi-agent when ownership or lifecycle split — never to look impressive.

BOOKING THE SEAT · PEARSON VUE

You book the seat early. You book it the right way.

Schedule up to 90 days in advance. Bring photo ID; eat before; do not bring reference material. The process is simple; the failure modes are note-able.

STEP 01 · LOCATE

Sign in to Microsoft Learn

Profile in place: name as on the ID, country, the email the credential will land at.

STEP 02 · SCHEDULE

Pick date, time, format

Test centre or OnVUE online proctored (rules differ). Most choose a centre.

STEP 03 · CONFIRM

Pay and watch for the email

Confirmation carries the cancellation window and reschedule rules. Read it once.

STEP 04 · SIT

Show up early

30 min before centre; 15 min grace for OnVUE. ID + confirmation + nothing else.

A TWO-WEEK PRE-FLIGHT

Practical habits that hold under proctor pressure

WEEK BEFORE

- Run two practice evals timed
- Re-read one scenario you got wrong
- Sleep twice — not just once

DAY BEFORE

- Pack ID, confirmation email, water
- Pin the address; save the PDF
- Decide centre vs OnVUE once

DURING THE EXAM

- First pass: flag, move on
- Re-read the question words, not yours
- Submit with ten minutes to spare

AFTER

- Note the score breakdown by domain
- Save the transcript PDF
- Book a retake only if scoring helps

ONVUE, IF YOU CHOOSE IT

Read the rules. Twice.

A clean desk; no second monitor; no phone. Glasses must be off-camera. Reschedule fees exist past 24 hours.

A retake is cheaper than panicking at minute 90.

READINESS · CAPSTONE

Readiness is a discipline, capstone is a proof.

The exam, then the room. Both want the same thing — a maker who ships, defends, and retires. Build the capstone the way the exam tests.

CAPSTONE · AN END-TO-END AGENT

STEP 01
Name the value
One sentence the team can repeat.

STEP 02
Pick envs & DLP
Dev, test, prod — walled.

STEP 03
Build the smallest
Topic — then add only.

STEP 04
Ground answers
Scope the source. Cite.

STEP 05
Add extensions
Only what closes a gap.

STEP 06
Validate
Eval set on the gate.

STEP 07
Ship & promote
Solution through pipeline.

STEP 08
Watch & retire
Telemetry, roles, sunset.

FOUR SIGNS YOU'RE READY

SIGNAL 1
You defend in one sentence
Each choice answers "why this, not that," in one breath.

SIGNAL 2
You name the second choice
A defensible runner-up means you understood the field, not the answer.

SIGNAL 3
You cite, then answer
Even on direct recall, you reach for the source — it's how trained reflexes form.

SIGNAL 4
You retire before you ship
You know who turns it off, when, and how — before the second user lands.

THE LAST WORD

Defend what you build — then let it go.

A shipped agent teaches you what to retire. Make the first version cheap enough to delete and brave enough to ship.

You are ready when nothing embarrasses you on day 90.